

Introduction

Not too far back in history, before the advent of digital photography, each photo was unique and special. A *photo* was the actual card, something you could carry in your wallet, frame and keep on your desk, or hang on a wall. Albums used to be meticulously preserved. Often, photographers used to insert handwritten captions on the back of the photo describing the event or particulars of the photograph.

Digital photography has changed how we handle photos, how we interact with them and even how we read them. What was once a costly affair, is now quite affordable. Anyone with a camera these days can claim to be an amateur photographer. This is, in a way, good. People are increasingly getting interested in photography. However, this does backfire at times as well, especially considering that the proliferation of images has reduced the ratio of inspiring shots to the run-of-the-mill ones that you come across everywhere.

Although veterans still hold out with film, and at times even black-and-white film, it would not be fair to classify all kinds of digital photography as being sub-standard or without merit.

Photography in the past century was a time-consuming process. Back then, there were no LCD screens on cameras to instantly know how your photos would turn out. It had to be the tough way out – trial and error. Enthusiasts and amateurs alike had to wait for as much as a month, probably more, to finish a film roll and develop it into hard copies. Photography was rather actively pursued back then – each photo delicately sought after, because it was a distinct image of a particular object, the individuality of each picture stood out.

Moreover, each shot had to be planned, the camera had to be understood, the lighting conditions evaluated, before the photographer even dared to open the shutter and decide to capture a particular scene. These are some of the things that are missed in these days of digital cameras. It took years of practice to make a half-decent photographer in the good old days of film, and digital cameras are now changing that.